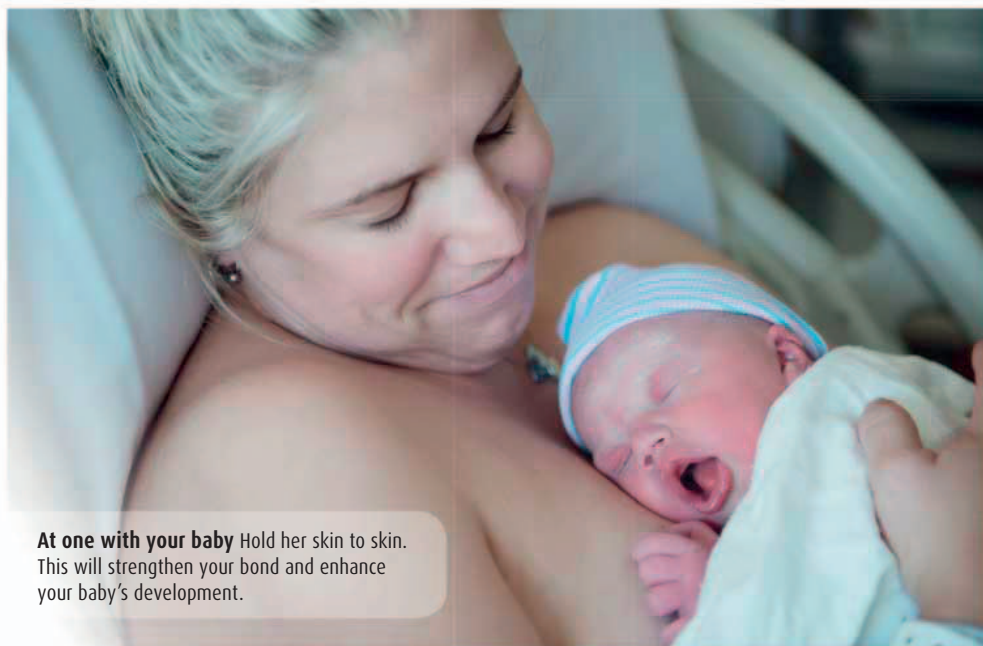


Q Do most people instantly fall in love with their baby?

Some people feel a rush of love, and some don't. If this feeling doesn't hit you right away, don't worry. For some bonding is a much more gradual process, but the relationship that develops in the end is just as strong and secure.

In the past, experts believed that there was a critical window for bonding shortly after birth, but we now understand bonding as a much more subtle, complex, and long-term process that develops in the days, weeks, and months following your baby's arrival. The deep attachment that comes with a strong and lasting bond is something that happens gradually over time. Holding your baby and taking care of her day to day will create a secure attachment, a sense of trust, and a growing mutual love that becomes immeasurable and profound. You may even be unaware that a bond is developing—for many parents, the first time they experience that heart-jumping jolt is the first time their baby smiles several weeks after the birth.



At one with your baby Hold her skin to skin. This will strengthen your bond and enhance your baby's development.

Bonding tips

» **Hold your baby close:** eventually your baby will need to learn to self-soothe and fall asleep alone, but in these early days and weeks cuddle with her as much as you want to.

» **Interact:** spend as much time as you can with your baby when she's awake: make eye contact; sing to her; talk to her. She can see you and hear you and this communication will only serve to strengthen the growing bond between you.

» **Make her your priority:** forget the chores and don't be afraid to accept help from others around you. These early weeks are precious so devote as much time as you can to your baby.

» **Limit visitors:** relatives and friends are bound to want to meet your new arrival, but in these early weeks try to stagger visitors. It's important to have time to spend together as a new family.

» **Give yourself time:** don't put pressure on yourself to feel or behave in a certain way. Try to relax and allow the relationship between you and your new baby to develop. If after several weeks you still feel detached, speak to your doctor.

Q It's a boy! I was sure I was having a girl. How should I adjust to this surprise?

Whether you have had a boy or girl, this is a time of enormous change. The first few days and weeks following childbirth are all about adjusting to the reality of having a small, fragile baby to take care of. In addition to this, your baby may look and behave differently from how you might have expected. You will also be experiencing a whirlwind of emotions due to hormone changes, exhaustion from the birth, and the hospital environment. Try to focus on bonding and getting to know your new baby.

This can take time, but as the days and weeks roll on, you will develop your own unique relationship, regardless of gender.

Q I am finding the first feedings difficult. Is this normal?

Rest assured that this is normal. Newborn babies are born with reserves and may not require much feeding during this time. Like you, your baby is probably exhausted from labor and birth and will sleep a lot. As a result she may be hard to feed. It may take time for both of you to get the hang of breast-feeding.

However, if you want to breast-feed, it is best to get this going as soon as possible. Enjoy skin-to-skin contact and put your baby to your breast every few hours, which will aid the production of breast-feeding hormones. If you are struggling, make sure to ask for guidance from a nurse or a lactation consultant.

On average, newborn babies tend to feed around 8 to 12 times a day, or more, in the first weeks after birth.